18, 1965, left *Voskhod 2 in* the original space "walk": "I looked down at the Earth," he recalls, "and the first thought that crossed my mind was 'The world *is* round, after all.' In one glance I could see from Gibraltar to the Caspian Sea … I felt like a bird—with wings, and able to fly."

When you view the Earth from farther away, as the *Apollo* astronauts did, it shrinks in apparent size, until nothing but a little geography remains. You're struck by how self-contained it is. An occasional hydrogen atom leaves; a pitter-patter of cometary dust arrives. Sunlight, generated in the immense, silent thermonuclear engine deep in the solar interior, pours out of the Sun in all directions, and the Earth intercepts enough of it to provide a little illumination and enough heat for our modest purposes. Apart from that, this small world is on its own.

From the surface of the Moon you can see it, perhaps as a crescent, even its continents now indistinct. And from the vantage point of the outermost planet it is a mere point of pale light.

From Earth orbit, you are struck by the tender blue arc of the horizon—the Earth's thin atmosphere seen tangentially. You can understand why there is no longer such a thing as a local environmental problem. Molecules are stupid. Industrial poisons, greenhouse gases, and substances that attack the protective ozone layer, because of their abysmal ignorance, do not respect borders. They are oblivious of the notion of national sovereignty. And so, due to the almost mythic powers of our technology (and the prevalence of short-term thinking), we are beginning—on continental and on planetary scales—to pose a danger to ourselves. Plainly, if these problems are to be solved, it will require many nations acting in concert over many years.

I'm struck again by the irony that spaceflight—conceived in the cauldron of nationalist rivalries and hatreds—brings with it a stunning transnational vision. You spend even a little time contemplating the Earth from orbit and the most deeply engrained nationalisms begin to erode. They seem the squabbles of mites on a plum.